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You'll walk away with: enough comfort to open a terminal, read what it's telling you, and move around in it, so the black screen stops being scary if you ever choose to use it.

First, the important part: this lesson is **completely optional**. The desktop app does everything in this course, and most members never open a terminal once. This is here for the curious, and for the day you want a little more control. If that's not you, skip it with zero guilt. Nothing later depends on it.

Still here? Good. The terminal is not what the movies made you think. Let's demystify it.

What the terminal actually is

It's a text conversation with your computer. That's the whole thing. Instead of clicking buttons, you type a short instruction, press enter, and the computer does it. The desktop app puts a friendly face on this. The terminal is just the same conversation with the face removed.

You are not "coding" when you use it. You're typing plain instructions, the same way you'd type a search.

How to open one

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Beginner Prompt Pack

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• **Windows:** click Start, type "Terminal" (or "PowerShell"), press enter.

• **Inside VS Code:** open the Terminal menu at the top, click "New Terminal". A panel opens at the bottom. This is the handiest one, because your code and your terminal sit side by side.

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To close it when you're done: type `exit` and press enter, or just close the window. Nothing breaks. Closing a terminal never deletes your work.

Reading the screen (the part nobody explains)

This is the bit that confuses everyone, so slow down here.

- **The prompt.** The line with a blinking cursor is the terminal waiting for you. It's saying "your turn." It often ends in a `$` or `%` or `>` symbol. That symbol is normal. You type after it.
- **"Nothing happened."** You run a command and no message appears. This is the single biggest source of panic, and it almost always means it worked. The terminal stays quiet when things go right and only speaks up when something is worth telling you. Silence is success.
- **Something is running.** If the cursor sits there and you can't type, a job is still working. Let it finish. When your prompt comes back, it's done.
- **An actual error.** Real errors are usually a block of red, or a line starting with words like "error" or "command not found." They look scarier than they are. Copy the text, paste it to Claude, and it'll tell you the one-line fix.

So the whole skill is reading three states: waiting for me, working, or telling me something. That's it.

The only two ways to move around

You'll use these to point the terminal at the right folder before you launch Claude Code:

- `cd foldername` moves you *into* a folder ("cd" means change directory). `cd my-business` walks you into your project.
- `ls` lists what's in the folder you're standing in, so you can see where you are.

That covers about 80 percent of moving around. Everything heavier, you'll let Claude handle.

 **Done when:** you can open a terminal, tell whether it's waiting, working, or erroring, and use `cd` and `ls` to land in the right folder.